

SELECTING THE RIGHT MULTI-FUNCTIONAL PRINTERS

Printing and managing documents has become one of the most important functions for any business. Today, in an era in which technology offers so many choices, selecting a multi-functional printer to suit your business can be confusing. Here are a few tips...



With huge amounts of information being shared even in small, start-up offices every day, having a cost-effective printing solution is a must. There are several solutions available in the market to meet your printing and document management requirements. Here's a guide to minimise your confusion and help you to take the right decision. It is always recommended that SMEs invest in a device that has capabilities beyond just printing. Such devices are commonly referred to as all-in-one printers (AIOs), multi-functional printers (MFPs) or even multi-functional devices (MFDs).

There are several aspects that need to be looked into while selecting a good MFP. The first thing to figure out, before you start exploring different options, is the printing, copying, scanning and other document handling requirements of the office. When searching for solutions for office use, you probably have to concentrate more on the quality of the text printing, rather than that of photos, which means you may need a laser printer that has a copier and scanning facility. An MFP with a fax, an automatic document feeder (ADF) to scan and the capability to send email will be an added advantage.

Features that you need to know about

All MFPs come with the basic features of printing, copying and scanning. A few have fax and emailing facilities too. Which one you opt for would depend on specific requirements. You have to decide whether you need an MFP with a fax, or whether you need a printer to just take colour and black and white prints, or whether the requirement is of a good quality scanner. If you need a good scanner, then you have to also decide on your scanning requirements, such as, whether you need an ADF or a flatbed scanner or a flatbed with ADF.

Apart from the features of the MFP you also need to have a look at the features available in the software bundled with it. There are many devices available in the market that can perform well only when connected to PCs with the relevant software installed.

Capacity, paper size and speed

While looking for printers, we must be clear about the exact capacity of the paper-holding trays. It would be very inconvenient to keep replenishing papers every now and then. One should also check the paper size supported. Speed of printing is the next thing we should look at while selecting any MFP. While you might assume that the printers capable of printing faster are better for your business, the reality is, your company's requirements might only justify purchasing a printer of a certain speed. Since features like high speed come at a price, it makes no sense paying for something you do not require. It's always recommended that you select a device that gives you the best ROI.

Connectivity

MFPs have various connectivity options. You can connect them to a system using a USB device or can connect through an Ethernet port. Most printers are also now available with Wi-Fi options. If you select a printer with Wi-Fi connectivity, do remember to ensure that you have a Wi-Fi network in place. There are other options too, but the most common are the ones mentioned above.

A few factors that may influence your decision are:

- The average number of prints that you need per month
- The quality of the scanner
- Connectivity options for communicating with the MFP
- Availability of duplex printing option
- Software compatibility with different operating systems
- Fax capability
- Printing cost per page
- Cost of toner/ink